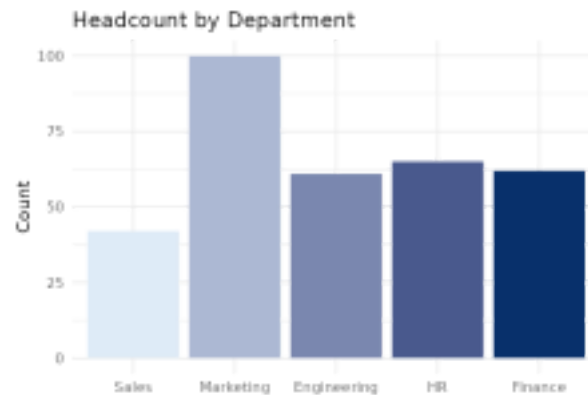


SESSION — ACTIVITY (20 MIN) • STUDENT HANDOUT • SLOT D

Redesign the Misleading Colored Chart

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Each chart below uses color in a misleading or confusing way. For each one, answer the three questions in your own words. Chart 1



1. What is this chart trying to show?

It compares the headcount (number of employees) of five departments: Sales, Marketing, Engineering, HR and Finance. Marketing has the most (about 100), Sales has the fewest (about 42), and the other three are around 60-65.

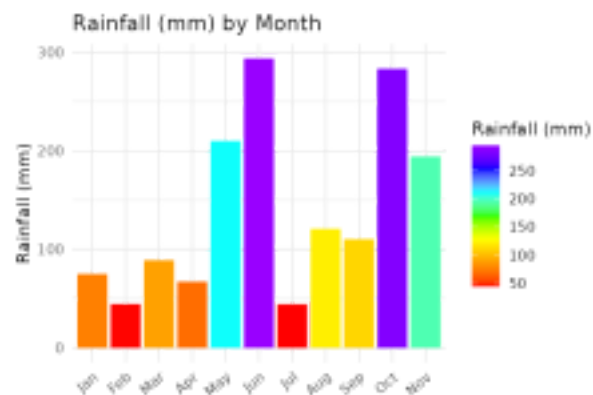
2. What's wrong with the color choice?

The bars use a light-to-dark blue gradient, which suggests an ordered scale, as if darker meant "more" or "better". But the departments are separate categories with no natural order, and the colors don't match the values. Marketing has the tallest bar but a light shade, while Finance is the darkest yet shorter than Marketing. The gradient adds no information, distracts the viewer, and makes the bars look like they follow a ranking or progression that doesn't exist.

3. Propose a better color scheme:

Use one single neutral color (for example, medium blue or grey) for all bars, since the bar height already shows the value. Sort the bars from highest to lowest. If one department needs attention (say, Marketing), highlight only that bar in a strong accent color such as orange and keep the rest grey. Label the bars directly so the color doesn't have to carry any meaning.

Chart 2



1. What is this chart trying to show?

It shows the monthly rainfall (in mm) from January to November, so the viewer can see which months are wet and which are dry. Rainfall peaks in June and October (about 280-290 mm) and is lowest in February and July (about 45 mm).

2. What's wrong with the color choice?

The chart uses a rainbow (red-yellow-green-cyan-blue-purple) color scale, which is misleading for several reasons:

- The colors have no natural order, so it's hard to tell whether green is more or less than yellow.
- The color changes unevenly, so some small differences look huge and some big differences are hard to see.

- Red normally means "high" or "danger", but here it marks the *lowest* rainfall.
- The color just repeats what the bar height already shows, which adds clutter.
- Rainbow scales are hard to read for color-blind viewers.

3. Propose a better color scheme:

Use a single-hue sequential scheme, such as light blue for low rainfall and dark blue for high rainfall, since blue naturally suggests water. The lightness should increase evenly with the value so the order is clear, and the scheme should be color-blind-friendly. A simpler option is to make all bars one blue and highlight only the wettest months (June and October) in a darker shade or an accent color.